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IGGERS



DEATH TOLL

A good percentage of the suicides in the paramilitary occurred in BSF and CRPF

FORCES	2004	2005	2006
BSF	35	43	44
CRPF	26	19	30
ASSAM RIFLES	10	15	20
CISF	6	11	8
SSB	1	6	6
ITBP	3	3	4

that the jawan is given a regular update on all the domestic problems and stressed by his inability to help resolve disputes," says a senior BSF official. In over 70 per cent of the cases, the suicide occurred after the jawan had returned to work from leave.

The maximum number of suicides were committed by married personnel—33 in 2004-05 as compared to 18 cases of unmarried jawans killing themselves. A majority of the deceased were in the age group 18-25, or soon after recruitment, and in the 31-40

LONE RANGERS: A paramilitary jawan remains with his family only for six years in his 35-year career

age bracket, or soon after marriage and children.

However, there are no signs that the Home Ministry, under which the CPFs function, has woken up to the seriousness of the issue. Presenting the statistics of paramilitary suicides in Parliament in March, Minister of State for Home Sripakash Jaiswal said there was no cause for concern. "There is no definite trend of increase in suicide and fratricide in paramilitary forces. Courts of inquiry have been ordered and necessary action taken, wherever required," he said. But ask D.K. Arya, former BSF DG, about the number of suicides in his two-year tenure, which began in 1994, and he says, "Not more than three or four a year, but things have changed since then." Today, the toll is 10 times higher and climbing.

The paramilitary forces say that stress—in the form of abysmal work conditions, atomised lives, long hours of work, constant mobility, marital disharmony, coupled with a constant threat to life—is the single biggest challenge they are facing. "The constant social pressures compounded by work pressure, loneliness and inability to meet one's family frequently lead to suicides," says a senior BSF official.

Despite mirroring the army's counter-insurgency and border-guarding responsibilities in the north and North-east, the paramilitaries say they have none of the support mechanisms, accommodation and welfare measures provided to army personnel. The army's concept of peace-time posting allows for rest after a two-year field posting to spend time with family. On the other hand, there is no respite for the paramilitary forces, which are stretched thin with counter-insurgency commitments and border postings. A CRPF battalion is made of seven companies comprising 75 men each. A company is rested for two months in a year, allowing jawans to spend time with their families. However, in the past two years, this rest has been availed by only 10 per cent of the force. Counter-insurgency commitments ensure that an average jawan remains with his family only for six years in his 35-year career.

The modernisation of the paramilitary

has been restricted to upgrading equipment, arms and ammunition. Some of the force's most pressing requirements—that of accommodation in different states—are yet to be taken care of. Only 12 per cent of the jawans' families have housing, as compared to a government target of at least 25 per cent. Jawans on duty are billeted in inhuman conditions, usually godowns or schools provided by the state government. Most of these billets, where jawans end up living for years, don't even have toilet facilities. BSF troopers have to cope with prolonged periods of loneliness on the border. The BSF post in Barmer, where Vishal Singh shot himself, is 14 km away from the nearest village. It is this remoteness which prevents civilian counsellors from visiting these paramilitary posts.

"It is time they knocked the 'reserve' off the CRPF; we are stretched so thin that we have absolutely no reserves," says a CRPF official. Eighty seven per cent of the force is actively deployed in counter-insurgency operations—39 per cent in Jammu and Kashmir, 29 per cent in the North-east and 19 per cent in fighting Naxals in interior India. They are also requisitioned for riot control. These deployments mean long working hours, usually at weeks on end. The Government has sanctioned 10 more CRPF battalions to be inducted by next year, but even these, officials say, will not be enough, since the force's commitments are vast.

Adding to the jawan's sense of helplessness is the Centre's recent decision to abolish pensions for recruits joining after 2004 (which the army is exempt from). This means a deceased jawan's family will only receive an ex-gratia amount of Rs 3 lakh. "Overall, there has been a lowering of morale and decreasing commitment to the national causes among the paramilitary forces," says Prakash Singh, former DG, BSF. "When a jawan is confronted with these causes, he sometimes chooses to kill himself." A raft of measures has been introduced over the past year—yoga classes, recreation facilities and games—to de-stress personnel. Over 30,000 men will take part in Art of Living classes this year. The Home Ministry hopes the paramilitary will get the message, but clearly the effect is yet to be felt. ■